

LegalBuddy

A question answering tool for Bangladesh law

Applicant: Istiaqur Rahman Fuad | **Email:** istiaqurrahmanfuad@gmail.com | **Area:** Legal technology

LegalBuddy is a question answering tool for Bangladesh law. You ask a question in plain English or Bengali, and instead of guessing, it first looks up the actual statute sections and related court judgments, then writes an answer that points back to those sources. A working version already searches the statutes and 8,493 court judgments through a web chat.

01 Problem Statement

Finding the right law and a relevant past judgment in Bangladesh takes a lot of manual work. The two things you need for almost any legal question, the governing statute and a relevant court precedent, are both hard to search.

- Statutes are spread across hundreds of acts and amendments. There is no good way to search them by meaning, so you have to already know which act to open.
- Court judgments are stored as scanned PDFs and old Bengali font files. A lot of the Bengali text comes out as broken characters, so normal search and copy paste do not work on them.
- Junior lawyers and law students spend hours just locating the correct section and a supporting case.
- General chatbots such as ChatGPT often make up section numbers and cases that do not exist, and they know very little about Bangladesh law in particular.

02 Solution

LegalBuddy answers questions about Bangladesh law by searching the real source material first. You ask a question in English or Bengali, and it finds the relevant statute sections and court judgments before writing an answer.

- It answers from retrieved text. Each answer points to the statute section it used, so the answer stays tied to the real law instead of being invented.
- It searches statutes and case law separately. Statutes give the rule to cite, and past judgments give context for the reasoning.
- It handles English and Bengali, including scanned pages and older Bengali fonts, using an OCR step that reads the page image instead of relying on the font.
- There is a working web version with a chat interface that streams the answer and shows the sources it used.

Planned next steps include letting users upload their own case files to search, short case summaries, and help with drafting simple notices.

03 Competitive Advantage

- Answers are tied to real statute text and checked against an evaluation set. In testing, the retrieval step was about 31 percentage points more accurate than a basic baseline.
- The court judgment data was the hard part. Turning 8,493 scanned and broken font judgments into clean, searchable text took real work, and that cleaned dataset is not easy to reproduce.
- It is built specifically for Bangladesh law and handles both English and Bengali, which general tools do not do well.

- It runs on open source embedding models, so there is no per query cost for the search step.
- It can be self hosted, which matters for firms that cannot send their files to an outside service.

04 Market Opportunity

Bangladesh has a large number of practising lawyers and many new law graduates each year, and the courts carry a large backlog of pending cases. Together this creates steady demand for tools that make legal research faster.

- Main users: law firms (junior lawyers and paralegals), solo practitioners, and law students, who do this kind of research every day.
- Other users: in house legal and compliance teams at banks, companies, and NGOs, along with law publishers and universities.
- Wider reach: ordinary people who need basic legal information but cannot afford to ask a lawyer for every question.
- The same setup can be pointed at other South Asian legal systems such as India, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka by swapping in their laws, since the structure is similar.

05 Business Model

LegalBuddy is a subscription tool with a free tier and paid plans, plus licensing for larger organisations.

Plan	Who	How it earns
Free	Students, general public	A limited number of questions per month.
Pro	Individual lawyers and students	Monthly plan with unlimited questions, full citations, and saved history.
Team	Law firms	Per seat pricing, a shared workspace, and private case file upload.
Enterprise and API	Publishers, universities, government	Yearly licence or metered API, with a self hosted option for sensitive data.

The paid individual and team plans are the main recurring income. Enterprise licences and API access add larger contract income. Because the search runs on open source models, the main cost per answer is a single model call, which keeps running costs low.